

Rosalina

The morning of the festival came with the promise of a day filled with laughter and celebration. The dew-kissed grass sparkled under the first rays of dawn, mirroring the excitement that spread through the vibrant gypsy encampment on the outskirts of the village. A wild symphony of color marked the area, with multi-hued tents and ribbons flapping in the gentle breeze. It was in this lively spectacle that the heart of their community beat, a heart named Rosalina.

Rosalina was like a sunbeam personified, bringing warmth and light wherever she went. Her long raven hair, free as the wind, was accentuated with wildflowers she had collected that morning. The blossoms were not just decorations; they were symbols of her affinity with nature and life. She wore a dress that flowed like the river, its blues and purples dancing in the light with every movement.

Before the rhythmic heartbeat of the festival had begun, Rosalina made her way to the musicians' tent. The Levski brothers, well-respected musicians in their community, were practicing with a noticeable edge of nervousness. As soon as Rosalina stepped into their world of melodies and tunes, she found herself pulled into their dance of anxiety.

The musicians were trying to find the right harmony, their faces lined with concentration. Rosalina felt the unspoken pressure hanging in the air and decided to lighten the mood. Picking up a tambourine, she danced into the circle of musicians, her steps and rhythm as natural as breathing.

Approaching the fiddler first, she matched her tambourine to his melody, her dance steps a silent encouragement. The fiddler's music grew stronger, his confidence finding wings.

Next was the flutist, his soft notes weaving seamlessly into the rhythm of Rosalina's tambourine. A small smile bloomed on his face as his tune became more fluid and sure.

One by one, she danced and played with each musician, her rhythm blending with their melodies. As each musician entwined with Rosalina's rhythm, they began to build off one another. The trepidation that had once held them captive melted away, replaced by the pure and simple joy of music.

Maruska passing by the musicians tent saw Rosalina dancing among the musicians. Her constant scowl grew just a bit deeper. "There's the camp peacock unfurling her tail feathers again" she muttered to the two other elder women walking just a few steps behind. The two elder women glanced at each other, rolling their eyes. "Why is she so sour all the time, and why so intensely toward Rosalina?" One whispered to the other; the other shrugging with a small sigh.

With the air filled with music, Rosalina then moved on to the cook's tent. It was a symphony of different aromas, the scent of exotic spices blending with the mouth-watering fragrance of roasting meats and baking bread. She found Matilde, the head cook, busily commanding a small army of kitchen helpers. Matilde's eyes were focused and intense, her lips set in a thin line.

"Matilde," Rosalina called out, drawing the older woman's attention. "You have been working tirelessly. The food smells divine!" She paused, casting a glance at the bustling kitchen, and added, "Remember to breathe, my friend. The festival won't be the same without your joyous laughter accompanying your delicious meals."

Matilde, though as she was reputed to be hard and stern in the kitchen, softened under Rosalina's genuine words. She gave a small nod, her lips curving into a smile, and for a brief moment, the kitchen's hectic pace seemed to slow down.

Stopping by a tent, she noticed a little girl, tears welling in her eyes as she held a broken doll. Rosalina knelt down, gently taking the doll from her hands. "Don't worry," she whispered, her fingers deftly fixing the doll's torn dress, "She'll be just fine." The little girl's tears dried, replaced by a wide, grateful smile.

Rosalina's journey through the festival was filled with moments like these, her kindness like a spark igniting the warmth in people's hearts. Her spirit was infectious, and her presence, much like her dance, was a rhythm that guided the heartbeat of the community.

However, not everyone basked in the warmth of Rosalina's sunshine. Wrinkled old Maruska watched with a hawk's intensity. She was a stark contrast to Rosalina, with her sour disposition and solitary lifestyle. As she watched Rosalina's interactions, her lips tightened with palpable disdain.

As the festival took on a life of its own, the camp now filled with laughter and music, Rosalina continued to weave through the crowd, leaving traces of kindness and joy in her wake. A group of children playing nearby looked up as she approached, their faces lighting up with anticipation. With a dramatic flourish, she produced a handful of colorful wildflowers from her bag, gifting each child with a bloom. Their giggles of delight were music to her ears, and she joined their laughter with her own, pure and heartwarming.

At the edge of the camp, a young man was struggling with the heavy water jugs for the evening's festivities. Without a moment's hesitation, Rosalina joined him, her slender arms surprisingly strong. They worked in silent unison, the jugs ready in no time. "Thank you, Rosalina," he said, admiration clear in his voice. With a warm smile and a nod, she moved on, her energy never faltering.

As night fell, the moon rose and cast a silver glow over the festival. The musicians, inspired by Rosalina's earlier interaction, filled the air with intoxicating melodies. Rosalina, in turn, responded with her dance, her movements as fluid and enchanting as the music itself.

As she spun and swayed with the rhythm, people watched in rapt admiration. Her dance was a storytelling of its own - a celebration of life, youth, and the joy of the present moment. The crowd was captivated, men and women, young and old, their eyes following her every move. Her dance was a vibrant painting brought to life, the festival providing the perfect canvas.

The young men present couldn't help but be drawn to her, their eyes reflecting clear admiration. A few young women watched Rosalina with expressions mirroring the same sentiment, their gazes soft and appreciative. Even the oldest of men, their youthful days a distant memory, had their eyes brighten at the sight of Rosalina's dance, a spark of the old fire rekindled within them.

But amid this enchantment, Maruska watched from the fringes. Her eyes, shadowed under the creased folds of her forehead, burned with a harsh intensity. Her lips curled into a sneer as she watched Rosalina sway, lost in her dance. The contrast was stark - the joyful festival against the backdrop of Maruska's brewing resentment.

As Rosalina's dance came to an end, applause and cheers filled the night, the camp caught in the spell she had cast. Panting slightly but with an unmissable spark in her eyes, Rosalina curtsied to the crowd, a smile playing on her lips. She was caught off guard, however, as a shrill voice sliced through the celebratory clamor.

"Parading like a peacock for all the young men, like a city harlot in her garish dresses!" Maruska called out, her tone laced with malice.

Rosalina turned towards the source of the voice, her expression composed. She met Maruska's gaze, her smile not wavering. "I merely dance to the rhythm, Maruska," she responded politely, "just like a bird merely sings to the dawn."

Murmurs rippled through the crowd, the tension palpable. However, Maruska wasn't finished. A few moments later, she made another jibe, "A gypsy woman should be humble and reserved, not a spectacle for the crowds."

This time, Rosalina's smile strained a bit, but she maintained her composure. "Maruska, we all contribute to the festival in our own way. This is mine."

With a "humf" Maruska, settled back into her darkened chair on the fringes of the revelry.

The music and the dancing started up again though there was now a palpable undercurrent of tension running through the festival goers. As the evening wore on, the tension was like a simmering pot ready to boil over. After a while the musicians took a break to refresh themselves clearly ready to play on into the early morning. Maruska, seizing the moment, threw another

insult, "You think you're better than us with your fancy dances and charming smiles. You're nothing but a pretty face!"

Rosalina's patience finally gave way. She looked Maruska straight in the eye, her voice cool and firm, "Maybe if you remembered your own youth, Maruska, you wouldn't be so bitter. Perhaps you were never the belle of the ball, seeing as you've spent your life alone."

A collective gasp echoed through the crowd. The truth of Rosalina's words stung, but the harshness of her tone left a bitter taste. As the words sank in, a silence settled over the crowd, the festival's joy momentarily forgotten. The conflict had been sparked, the fiery exchange between the young woman and the old crone now unveiled for all to see.

It was later that night, under the vast canvas of the starlit sky, that Rosalina found Maruska alone. "Maruska, I..." she started, her voice laced with regret.

But Maruska interrupted her with a wave of her hand, her eyes devoid of their usual fire. "Save your apologies, Rosalina," she said bitterly. "You've shown your true colors."

Rosalina could only watch as Maruska retreated to her tent, her heart heavy with regret. She didn't see the older woman's hands trembling as she started her preparations for an ancient summoning ritual, a fiery revenge taking shape in her mind.

With the festival's joyous celebration faded into the background, the quiet of the night was disturbed only by the crackle of bonfires and the distant sounds of night creatures. The heart of the camp was alive with flickering shadows and the low hum of residual excitement.

In the gloom of her tent, Maruska busied herself preparing, muttering under her breath. Ancient texts lay spread out around her, their pages brittle with age, the ink faded but the words etched in her memory. Her hands shook as she collected the required items - a pouch of precious gemstones, a vial of sacred oil, a chalice filled with moon water.

Closing her eyes, she began to recite an ancient incantation, her voice a trembling whisper. The air inside the tent grew warm, almost stifling. The fire in the small brazier flickered violently as a whirlwind seemed to form above it. Then, as suddenly as it had started, everything stilled.

When Maruska opened her eyes, an Efreeti stood before her. His body seemed made of living flame, flickering and dancing in the dim light of the tent. His eyes, a deep, fiery orange, looked at her with curiosity.

"I am Azaar," he announced, his voice like the roar of a bonfire. "Why have you summoned me, old crone?"

Maruska's heart pounded in her chest, but she managed to keep her voice steady. "Azaar, I seek your aid. I desire a wish to be granted."

The Efreeti tilted his head, studying her. "And what is this wish that you desire?"

"I want you to fall deeply, passionately in love with a woman named Rosalina," Maruska said, her voice filled with a strange mixture of bitterness and hope. "And I want her to fall just as deeply in love with you."

Azaar looked taken aback for a moment, then he chuckled, a warm, crackling sound. "And what would you gain from this, old woman?"

Maruska shrugged. "In the very least revenge, at most a vacuous peacock learns what it means to know pain and loss."

Azaar studied her for a long moment, then he shrugged, a playful smirk on his face. "As you wish, Maruska. Your command is my desire."

The Efreeti disappeared in a burst of flame, leaving Maruska alone in her tent, her heart filled with a strange sense of satisfaction.

The next morning, as the festival resumed, Rosalina found herself face to face with a man she'd never seen before. His eyes held a deep, fiery glow that seemed strangely familiar, and his smile was as warm as the morning sun.

"I am Azaar," he introduced himself, his voice as intoxicating as the most potent wine. "And I think I'm in love with you."

Rosalina was taken aback. She looked into his eyes and found a depth of emotion that left her breathless. His words, though strange and unexpected, stirred something within her, and for reasons she couldn't understand, she found herself saying, "I think I'm in love with you too, Azaar."

The days that followed were a whirlwind of love and passion. The community watched with bemusement and delight as the normally composed Rosalina lost herself in the throes of a love so deep, so intense, it was almost supernatural. Even Maruska watched from the sidelines, her heart heavy with a mixture of regret and satisfaction.

Their love was like a flame, burning bright and fierce. Azaar's energy was contagious, his generosity unmatched. Rosalina, under his influence, seemed even more vibrant, more full of life. Their joy was palpable, their love undeniable.

Azaar's radiant spirit infused the gypsy camp with renewed energy. He was like the morning sun, dispersing the gloom of night and warming the air with his infectious joy. The youngsters marveled at his strength when he joined them in their games, the men nodded approvingly at

his tales of distant lands and adventures, and the women were charmed by his respectful manner and flattering compliments.

Rosalina, basking in the warmth of Azaar's love, seemed to glow with an ethereal beauty. Her laughter rang out more often, her eyes sparkled with an inner light, and her kindness was amplified by her boundless joy. Together, they were a mesmerizing spectacle, their love story unfolding like a riveting play that held the entire community captive.

One evening, they sat by the campfire, their hands clasped, eyes locked. Azaar, in his soothing voice, told Rosalina stories of the Efreeti and their lives, painting vivid pictures of the fiery planes from where he came. Rosalina listened, her heart pounding with a mix of fear and fascination, and love for the being before her.

"Do you miss it?" she asked, her voice barely above a whisper, her eyes searching his.

Azaar smiled, his thumb gently caressing the back of her hand. "Sometimes. But what I have here, with you, it's more than I could ever dream of."

Rosalina's heart swelled at his words, her love for him growing deeper. They shared stories, dreams, and laughter, their bond strengthening with each passing moment.

A few days into their shared love, during the culmination of the festival, a special night descended. It was a night of shared stories and dancing, a time when everyone was equal under the moonlight. As the moment for the festivities of the night approached a group of women of all ages swooped in whisking Rosalina away and a group of somber men led by one of the caravan's elders approached Azaar, the elder saying "Come with us Azaar."

Rosalina found herself in a whirlwind of giggling young women, strong and confident middle aged women releasing the straps of her dress and a few of the elder women unveiling a excruciatingly beautiful flowing dress its white base hardly visible amongst the fiery red, gold and orange inlays and beadwork of the bodice, and the long flowing skirt made of of many layered strips of fabric in every color of the sunset sky. As they settled the dress on her shoulders Rosalina seemed to glow like the setting sun, as the realization struck that the caravan was about to engage her and Azaar.

Meanwhile the group of men led Azaar over to a covered wagon where some of the men busied themselves finding a dark suit that would fit Azaar. The younger men raising toasts with goblets of wine. The elder Nicolae approached Azaar.

"You may not be familiar with our customs, Azaar." said the elder.

"Friend," Azaar said in his cheerful bonfire voice with a smile. Then after a moment of thought his demeanor grew somber, Azaar knelt before the elder and said "Respectfully Elder Niccoli. I am privy to all of the knowledge of the Efreeti, I know your customs from the day the first wagon

wheel was tempered with fire. Everything your people have done in the presence of the merest of candle flames or even the dying embers in the hearth my people have heard, seen and remember.” Azaar took a moment, sorrow seeming to flash across his face. “You and your caravan intend to make us heartfast, promised to one another.”

“Yes, we do.” said Nicoli, “but you don’t appear all that happy with it.” Concern playing across his face.

“It is not that I am unhappy, I would pledge eternity to Rosalina in an instant. However, Efreeti do not live long by human standards, the truth is that dawn tomorrow marks the last day of my life, and the first rays of the following day I will be naught but ash.

Nicoli, eyes wide with shock, took a breath and considered this new knowledge. “You are afraid that if Rosalina knew about your lifespan it would sour the joy of the love you share, but also fear that becoming heartfast will increase the depth of her loss when you are gone?”

“Yes.” Said Azaar, his eyes holding Nicoli’s in a steady and serious gaze.

“You are being a fool Azaar! You live in the moment, passion for life pouring forth from you igniting that passion in everyone around you.” said Nicoli, a mask of joy smoothing his furrowed brow. In a quiet voice only for Azaar’s ears, “as for tomorrow Rosalina has all of us to support her through the sorrow and remind her of the Joy the two of you share.”

The other men found a vest and pants to fit Azaar’s tall frame, in a deep midnight blue, his luminous golden skin like a bonfire in the night.

Then Nicoli led Azzar to the edge of the dance circle and bid him to wait as he walked to the center of the circle. On the opposite side of the circle stood Rosalina, resplendent in the center of a gaggle of giddy young women.

When Nicoli reached the center of the circle we waited a moment then cleared his throat. Slowly silence spread across the gathered crowd.

“Today we have gathered to revel in the live we are gifted with, in this festival” Nicoli’s clear rich voice rang out. “This year we have something to add to the joy of the festival. That is the love and joy between Rosalina and Azaar. As tradition holds when a love so bright graces our caravan, the caravan takes measures to protect that love. So do our people declare this love heartfast?”

A resounding cheer rose from the crowd, glasses raised, cheerful and joyous faces all around. Except one, Maruska, whose general sour demeanor has been replaced by what can only be called heartsick.

“Then as you command I find Rosalina and Azaar to be hearfast!” roared Nicolli

Again the crowd cheered.

Nicoli holding his hands up calling for silence once again. The crowd quieted once again with quizzical looks on their faces.

“And in breaking with tradition,” Nicoli said with a broad grin on his face. “Knowing this couple as we all do, I see no reason that the two should not be wed.”

Both Rosalina and Azarr’s eyes grew wide with surprise and a hushed murmur ran through the crowd.

“Does anyone here see any reason that they should not?” called Nicoli, his gaze alighting on Maruska and holding her in a stare of defiance. Maruska finally turned away, no one noticing the tears beginning to well up in her eyes.

“Do you Rosalina wish to marry Azaar?” Nicoli called out turning to Rosalina

In a state of wondrous shock, much like the day Azaar appeared Rosalina replied in her strong melodious voice “yes I think I do.”

“Do y...” Began Nicoli.

With a voice as warm and rich as a crackling hearth fire “I think I do too.” interrupted Azaar, his smile melting every heart within a mile.

Roaring with laughter “Then I pronounce you married!”

One more cheer rang out from the crowd. People engulfed Rosalina and Azaar with congratulatory hugs. And then a long loud note rang out from the fiddle, and a song of pure passion flowed from the fiddle drawing in the rest of the musicians. Rosalina whirled out of the group congratulating her, like the sun breaking through a cloudy day at sunset. As she reached the center of the dance circle she stopped eyes locking with Azaar.

A hair's breadth of a moment passed, and Azaar burst into the circle like the flames of a bonfire in the night, sparks floating from his hair.

The couple stood together in the center of the circle, just looking into one another's eyes. Azaar, tall and radiant with his fiery charm. Rosalina, the wind playing in her hair, her eyes glistening with shared emotion.

Then they moved. The dance began slowly, a gentle sway, their bodies moving in sync with the rhythm. The onlookers watched, their breaths held, as Rosalina and Azaar moved around the fire-lit space. There was something undeniably magical about the sight; the young gypsy

woman, all fiery spirit and kind heart, dancing with an Efreeti, a creature of pure passion and transient existence.

Azaar moved with the fluidity of a flame in the breeze, his steps fiery yet graceful. Rosalina, on the other hand, danced like the wind itself, her movements swift and full of life. They spun and twirled, their dance a vivid picture of their blazing love story.

It was as if the world was dancing with them. The flames from the bonfire leaped and twirled in harmony with their moves, casting a warm, golden glow on their faces. The breeze swirled around them as if in a dance of its own, rustling leaves and whispering sweet nothings. Even the stars seemed to twinkle in rhythm with their passionate dance.

The gypsy community watched, completely captivated by the enchanting spectacle. Young men and women looked on with wide-eyed wonder, the older ones with knowing smiles. The sight of Rosalina and Azaar, their love manifest in their passionate dance, breathed new life into the night.

As the last note of the fiddle's melody echoed through the air, Rosalina and Azaar stopped, standing close, their foreheads touching, their breaths mingling. The entire camp burst into applause, their claps and cheers filling the night air.

From that moment on, the tale of Rosalina and Azaar's dance under the moonlit sky became a story to be told and retold. It was a dance that embodied their passion, their love, and the transient beauty of life. Their dance was a memory that lingered, a reminder of a love so intense and so vibrant that it warmed even the coldest of hearts.

In the midst of all this, Maruska observed them from a distance. Her eyes held a mysterious blend of pain and satisfaction. The sight of Rosalina and Azaar, so deeply in love, conjured memories of a past she had long buried. In her heart, an old flame flickered, stirring echoes of a love she too once experienced, a love that was as fierce, as fleeting, and as heartbreaking.

As she watched them dance under the starlit sky, their laughter echoing around the camp, her heart ached with a pang of sympathy and regret. In their joy, she saw a reflection of her own past and a harbinger of the sorrow that awaited Rosalina.

In the midst of the community's everyday bustle, a radiant pair of lovers, a girl and an Efreeti, left their mark. They were a reminder of love's enchanting beauty and its heartbreaking impermanence, a symbol of a love story that was destined to be both beautiful and tragic. For in their joy was intertwined an impending sorrow, and in their love, a tale as old as time.

As the days danced along with the lovers, the community became enwrapped in their magical affection. Young girls giggled and whispered behind their hands, dreaming of a love as profound as Rosalina's and Azaar's. Older women watched them, their faces softened by the sweet ache of nostalgia.

Yet, as the sun traced its seventh arc across the sky since Azaar's arrival, a subtle change occurred. Azaar seemed to grow a little quieter, his infectious energy a touch dimmed. Rosalina noticed, her heart pounding with an unnameable fear. She questioned him, and he brushed her worries aside with a tender kiss and a reassurance.

"Perhaps, I have just been indulging too much in the festivities, my love," Azaar said, a mischievous twinkle in his eyes.

That evening, at the communal fire, Azaar's tales of his homeland grew more vibrant, more heartfelt, as if he was saying goodbye to a part of himself. Rosalina clung to his every word, the fear in her heart growing despite his assurances.

That night, as the moon bathed their tent in silver light, Azaar held Rosalina closer than ever before. His heartbeat echoed in her ears, a fierce, fiery rhythm that was both a comfort and a reminder of his otherworldly origin.

"I want you to promise me something, Rosalina," he whispered, his breath warm against her ear.

Rosalina turned her face to his, her eyes searching his in the dim light. "Anything, Azaar."

His hands cupped her face, his thumbs gently brushing away the tears that had started to form in her eyes. "Promise me you will remember our love, not with sorrow, but with joy. Remember the laughter, the stories, the dances, everything we've shared. Can you promise me that, my love?"

A sob caught in Rosalina's throat. The fear had a name now. Loss. But she nodded, pressing her lips to his in a passionate kiss. They held each other through the night, their bodies entwined, their heartbeats echoing each other, until sleep claimed them both.

As the sun started to rise, painting the sky with hues of pink and gold, Rosalina awoke to find Azaar's side of the bed cold and empty. Panic seized her, and she rushed out of their tent, her heart hammering in her chest. Her eyes found him near the bonfire, his body convulsing, his skin flickering like dying embers.

The gypsy camp awoke to Rosalina's heartbroken wails. Azaar, the Efreeti who had been a beacon of joy, was no more. As the sun fully rose, the fire that was Azaar extinguished, leaving behind a bereft Rosalina and a community in mourning.

The sun hung high in the sky, a mocking testament to the joy that should have been in the wake of the festival. Rosalina sat alone, her eyes staring into the smoldering embers of what had been Azaar. Her heart echoed the same dull ache, the vibrancy of love extinguished too soon. The usually vibrant camp was silent, the music and laughter of the last week now a haunting memory.

Suddenly, a familiar, grating voice broke the silence. "He was an Efreeti, Rosalina," Maruska said, her usually sharp voice softened by an uncharacteristic gentleness. She came to sit beside Rosalina, her eyes also locked onto the dying embers.

"Azzar told me all about the ethereal plane of fire and that he was an Efreeti," said Rosalina.

Maruska sighed, her gaze distant. "Ah but he did not tell you that Efreeti live for only seven days? He wouldn't have, he would not want the knowledge of his short life to taint the joy of your love. Efreeti burn brightly and passionately, and then, like a shooting star, they extinguish."

The silence between Rosalina and Maruska stretched, fraught with newfound understanding and shared sorrow. Finally, Maruska broke the silence, her voice strained with emotion.

"I need to confess something to you, Rosalina," she began, her eyes avoiding the young woman's gaze. "I... I summoned Azaar. I wished for him to love you and set him free. It was my anger and envy that caused all this."

Rosalina stared at Maruska, a shock of betrayal washing over her. "You...you did what?" she managed to choke out, her voice a mere whisper.

Maruska nodded, her eyes filled with remorse. "I did, Rosalina. I was envious... and bitter. Your beauty, your spirit, the way you were loved by everyone... It reminded me of what I had lost, what I had pushed away. I thought that by bringing you an Efreeti love, I could make you understand the pain of losing something so precious."

The older woman took a deep, shaky breath, her voice faltering. "I thought your beauty was only skin deep. I never imagined that you and Azaar could truly fall in love. I never thought I would see in your eyes the same love that once shone in mine."

Rosalina sat in stunned silence, her mind reeling from Maruska's confession. "But why... why would you wish this pain on me?" she asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Maruska reached out, taking Rosalina's hand in her own. "I see now that it was a mistake. I see now that the love you shared with Azaar was true, as true as the love I had for Azibo. I... I regret causing you this pain, this heartache. I regret the solitude that will now be your life."

Rosalina felt a tear slide down her cheek, the enormity of Maruska's confession leaving her feeling raw and exposed. Yet, in the midst of her pain, there was a glimmer of something else. Understanding. Compassion. Shared sorrow. And perhaps, a path towards healing. For both of them.

A year had passed since Azaar's departure, a year of mourning and healing, of understanding and acceptance. The annual Gypsy Festival was once again upon the community, vibrant as ever, yet it bore a lingering shadow of the previous year's events.

Rosalina, her heart still heavy, was adorned in her bright, beautiful clothes but her eyes held a sadness that had never been there before. As she prepared to step out of her wagon, a familiar figure approached.

Maruska, no longer viewed as the bitter crone but as a woman who bore her own scars, was now a steady presence in Rosalina's life. She came carrying a handful of ribbons, their colors reminding Rosalina of Azaar's fire, a brilliant combination of red and orange.

Without a word, Maruska began to braid the ribbons into Rosalina's hair. Each stroke, each intertwining of color was a silent apology, a gentle reassurance.

"You need to remember, child," Maruska said, her voice soft and low. "Remember the love, the joy, the happiness. Remember him as he was, full of life and passion. Dance for him, Rosalina. Dance to celebrate his life, your love."

Rosalina turned, drawing a fiery orange poppy from her bag and threading the stem into Maruska's hair. Maruska reached up and took Rosalina's hand, they looked into each other's eyes shimmering with unshed tears. Silently expressing all that the two mean to one another. Nodding, Rosalina squeezed Maruska's hand in gratitude, and turned to face the dance circle. The crowd parted as Rosalina approached, the music quieted and stilled. When she reached the center of the circle she made eye contact with each musician in turn then nodded her head. The music started slowly, building with each instrument in turn joining the melody. Rosalina began to sway, feeling the rhythm and the melody. As the movement and the music kindled the fire in her heart, she pushed against the rhythm, the musicians feeling that push and passion speeding the tempo, letting Rosalina's dance act as their conductor.

Her body swayed with the music, every twirl, every step a testament to the love she had for Azaar. Her dance was not one of sorrow but of celebration. A celebration of love, of life, of the memories she shared with Azaar.

The onlookers, entranced by the spectacle, felt a collective emotion stir within them. It was a poignant reminder of love, of loss, but also of healing. Maruska watched from the sidelines, a small smile playing on her lips, her heart heavy with regret but also with hope.

Rosalina's dance continued, her movements growing more fluid, more passionate. The rhythm of the music, the beat of the drums matched the rhythm of her heart. And in her dance, they saw Rosalina's resilience, her strength, her capacity to love and to heal. As the dance reached its height the wind began to swirl making the bonfire dance right alongside her, the feel of the breeze on her cheek reminding her of Azaar's gentle touch.

As the final notes of the music faded, Rosalina stopped, her chest heaving, her face flushed. Her dance had been more than a performance; it was a declaration, a promise. A promise to remember, to cherish, and to continue living. For herself. For Azaar.

The crowd erupted into applause, their cheers filling the night. As Rosalina looked around, she felt a sense of peace wash over her. She knew that she would never forget Azaar, that she would always cherish the love they shared. But she also knew that she would keep living, keep loving.

For Azaar. For herself. For love. And in the end, that's all that mattered.

epilogue

Three elder women sit around a bonfire set a short distance from the main caravan. Maruska with a fiery red shawl with golden tassels. Soraya is a soft round faced woman with rich brown eyes, wearing a green shawl with mahogany beads on the fringe. And Drina, a tall woman with surprisingly smooth skin for a woman with pure white hair and an elder for the caravan, wearing a blue flowing shawl with clear beads throwing rainbows from the fire on her cheek.

"Maruska, are you going to tell her about the nature of the elemental realm of fire, and that his aspect can be felt when touching that place?" Says Drina quietly, a mildly stricken look on her face.

Maruska staring solemnly into the fire, "no, not anytime soon any way. She can never touch that place and feel that in the throbbing dance of the fire realm."

"How can you know that Maruska?" Soraya replies.

"I know that because her aspect is air and that will be the only elemental realm she will ever touch."

Surprise plays across the face of the two women. "Are you sure Maruska, it has been so long since a new aspected was born!" Soraya exclaimed breathlessly

"I have not felt the pull of a new element. What makes you think this young woman, talented, strong and selfless as she is, carries an aspect?" said Drina with a skeptical expression on her face.

"Oh, you can feel it, just have not realized it yet. Have you ever felt an air aspect before? No? Not surprising air aspects are rare, this is likely the first one any of us has encountered. I know she is the first I have encountered." Maruska explains

Maruska continues "I have spent much more time in close contact with her. And I have suspected for some time she might have a talent, but tonight I felt it for sure. Not only did I feel that light and ephemeral aspect, but I saw it, the wind was dancing with her this evening. And she caressed my cheek with the wind when we locked eyes during her dance. You can feel it now if you try, reach up and out, spread yourself thin and let her aspect touch you."

The two women closed their eyes letting their spirit reach up and out of themselves and made their spirits thin like sails in the night sky. Soraya gasped and Drina's eyes went wide when they each felt the gentle constant pressure pushing against their psyche.

"She will need to be guided." Drina says wonder and concern plainly written on her face.

"Agreed." replied the other two women.